
Yellow Seoul

A Ginkgo Road Walking Guide

A November Color Different from Autumn Leaves

****Subtitle****

If red autumn leaves (#229) belong to the mountains
yellow ginkgo belongs to the city

Why Ginkgo Gets Its Own Guide

Seoul autumn's last scene isn't red — it's **yellow**. The ginkgo is the signature street tree of Seoul, so unlike autumn leaves, which mean a trip to the mountains, **all of downtown turns yellow at once**. The peak comes later than autumn leaves, in **late October to early November** — the last seasonal card left for late-autumn travelers who missed the red leaves.

Category	Autumn Leaves (#229)	Ginkgo (this guide)
Color	Shades of red	Solid yellow
Stage	Mountains · palace gardens	Downtown streets · street trees
Peak	Mid-late October	Late October – early November
Effort	Often involves hiking	All flat, walkable

① 6 Ginkgo Spots

1. Sungkyunkwan Ginkgo (성균관 문묘 은행나무) — The King of Seoul's Ginkgos

- A giant tree over 400 years old standing in front of Myeongnyundang (명륜당), the lecture hall of Sungkyunkwan (성균관), Joseon's top educational institution — designated a Natural Monument (천연기념물, Korea's official protected-heritage-tree status). When it turns fully yellow, the scale dwarfs every other ginkgo in Seoul.
- 10-minute walk from Hyehwa Station (혜화역). Pairs into a half-day course with Daehangno (대학로) and Naksan Park (낙산공원, #1308). Peak-week weekends bring a photo crowd — weekday mornings are the answer.

2. Deoksugung Stone Wall Road (덕수궁 돌담길) · Jeongdong-gil (정동길) — The Most Seoul-Like Yellow Street

- A combination of palace stone walls and ginkgo-lined streets. Right from City Hall Station (시청역) — the best accessibility of the six. If your visit overlaps the stretch when fallen leaves are left unswept (a customary fallen-leaf-festival practice in past years), even the ground underfoot turns yellow.
- A historic walking course that pairs with modern architecture — head toward Jeongdong Church (정동교회) and the former Russian Legation (구 러시아공사관).

3. Garosu-gil (가로수길), Sinsa-dong (신사동) — The Name Itself Means 'Ginkgo Street'

- The street trees in Garosu-gil ("street of trees") are ginkgos. A shopping district paired with a yellow tunnel — early-November afternoons are the peak.

4. Samcheong-dong-gil (삼청동길) · Gamgodang-gil (감고당길) — Galleries and Ginkgos

- Ginkgos line the gallery-and-cafe alleys along the eastern wall of Gyeongbokgung (경복궁). A course that fits naturally into a Bukchon (북촌, #38) itinerary.

5. Around Songpa Olympic Park (송파 올림픽공원) + Seokchon Lake (석촌호수), Jamsil (잠실) — The Southeast-Seoul Option

- After the grass season (pink muhly), late autumn brings a yellow path circling the lake — links into a Jamsil itinerary.

6. Yongmunsa Ginkgo (양평 용문사 은행나무) — The Peak of a Day-Trip Pilgrimage

- About 1,100 years old, one of East Asia's largest ginkgo trees — a Natural Monument. Reachable as a day trip on the Gyeongui-Jungang Line (경의중앙선); combine it with the Gapyeong (가평) · Yangpyeong (양평) day-trip guide #739 to fill out a full day.
- During peak week in early November, people travel from all over the country just to see one tree — it's worth the trip.

+7. Seochon · Gyeongbokgung Stone Wall Extension Route — The Order Local Accounts Walk It

The **Gyeongbokgung west stone wall ginkgo route** that Bukchon local guide accounts post every autumn, based on their own on-the-ground walks. A bonus course that goes one layer deeper than the 6-spot list above (all free, all flat).

- **National Palace Museum of Korea (국립고궁박물관) Ginkgo Rest Area** (Hyoja-ro 12 / 효자로 12) — Ginkgo shade with benches right next to Gyeongbokgung's west entrance. A rest spot in summer, a yellow photo spot in autumn.
- **Tongui-dong Village Square (통의동 마을마당)** (Tongui-dong 7-3 / 통의동 7-3) — A ginkgo tree in a small empty lot tucked into a Seochon alley. Almost no tourists.
- **Jahamun-ro 6-gil (자하문로6길) · Seochon Stone Wall Road** — Ginkgo trees running along Gyeongbokgung's west wall. Extend it to Cheongwadae-ro (청와대로) and a view of Sinmumun (신무문, Gyeongbokgung's north gate) and you've got a Seochon half-day.
- **Yun Posun-gil (윤보선길) · Songhyeon Green Plaza (열린송헌 녹지광장)** — An extension that connects naturally from Gamgodang-gil (No. 4 on the 6-spot list).
- **Baek In-je House (백인제가옥)** (Bukchon) — A hanok garden combining autumn leaves and ginkgo. The Bukchon autumn shot that gets the hottest reaction from local accounts.

② How to Predict the Peak — Ginkgo Is More Sensitive Than Autumn Leaves

- Downtown Seoul's ginkgo peak generally falls in the **last week of October to the first week of November**. It still shifts by a few days each year — checking the latest #은행나무 tag on Instagram right before your trip is the most accurate live update.
- **One rainstorm ends it** — peak yellow leaves fall after a single strong rain or gust of wind. If rain is forecast during peak week, treat the day before the rain as this year's last day and move accordingly.
- Even the **yellow carpet** right after the leaves fall is a spectacle in its own right for a day or two — don't give up just because you're running late.

Pre-Trip Prep Checklist

- [] **Check your travel week** — does it fall within the late-October-to-early-November window? Too early, swap in the grass season; too late, swap in the first winter illuminations.
- [] **Reserve a morning slot** — weekday mornings see the fewest crowds at Sungkyunkwan and Deoksugung.
- [] **Brace for the smell** — ginkgo fruit from female trees has a strong odor when stepped on. Watch your footing where fruit has fallen — check your soles before heading back into your accommodation.
- [] **Set a weather-app alert** — rain in the forecast during peak week is your signal to move your visit earlier.
- [] **Dress for the seasonal shift** — early-November mornings in Seoul run 5–10°C (41–50°F) — layer up (Monthly Clothing Guide #518).

Keep Reading

- **#229 Autumn Leaves Full Guide · #89 Top 8 Autumn Foliage Spots** — the red version
- **#739 Gapyeong · Yangpyeong Day Trip** — combine with the Yongmunsa pilgrimage
- **#38 Bukchon · #1308 Sunset Spots** (Naksan) — a route linking Samcheong-dong and Sungkyunkwan
- Silver grass · pink muhly grass season (upcoming) — the season right before this one

Verification Notes (Pre-Publish Check)

- **Fact anchor:** the Seoul Munmyo (Sungkyunkwan) ginkgo (성균관 은행나무) = a giant tree designated a Natural Monument, over 400 years old / the Yongmunsa ginkgo = a Natural Monument, about 1,100 years old, one of East Asia's largest / the name Garosu-gil comes from its ginkgo street trees / Seoul's ginkgo peak commonly falling in late October–early November — all publicly known facts. The leaf-preservation and festival practices are qualified as "based on past years."
- **Creative boundary:** no specific store names. No firm peak dates asserted (a prediction method is offered instead). Ginkgo odor is presented only as fact-based, practical information.
- **Coverage check:** zero prior pieces on the ginkgo axis (checked against contents.json, 2026-08-20).

Tags

#GinkgoSeoul #YellowSeoul #Sungkyunkwan #DeoksugungStonewall #Garosugil #Yongmunsa
#LateAutumn #KeyChinGu